The Pivot Method: Quick Guide to Career Change (Mini Guide)

I'm sharing the text version here on LinkedIn. But if you want the fully designed guide with all the visuals, get it free HERE.

Based on "Pivot: The Only Move That Matters Is Your Next One" by Jenny Blake

By James Bugden • Senior Recruiter

Why This Guide Exists

I've hired 500+ people at companies like Uber and Netskope. I've reviewed over 20,000 resumes. And the pattern I see most often is this: talented people stuck in the wrong career, making the wrong moves to get out.

They quit without a plan. They start from scratch in a totally different field. They apply to 200 jobs online and wonder why nobody calls back.

Jenny Blake's book "Pivot" lays out a smarter method. It's the same approach I've seen work for the best career changers I've hired. This guide breaks it down through a recruiter's lens what I actually see work (and fail) from the hiring side of the table.

Read the full version at [LEAD_MAGNET_URL] for the deep dive with exercises and detailed examples. This is the condensed version; the framework, the key actions, and the mistakes to avoid.

What Is a Career Pivot?

A pivot is **doubling down on what's working to shift in a new, related direction.** You're not starting from scratch. You're using your existing strengths, skills, and connections to move into something better.

Think of it like basketball: one foot stays planted (your foundation) while the other explores new territory.

A pivot is NOT:

- Quitting your job with no plan
- Starting over in a totally different field
- A midlife crisis or breakdown

A pivot IS:

- A planned, step-by-step process
- Building on what you already have
- Testing before committing
- Reducing risk while exploring

Why this matters now: Average job tenure is 4-5 years. You'll likely have 11+ jobs and change industries 3-6 times in your career. The question isn't whether you'll pivot — it's whether you'll do it well or badly.

The 5 Stages

Most people skip straight to Stage 4 (making the big move) without doing the work in Stages 1-3. That's why most career changes feel chaotic instead of strategic.

🌱 Stage 1: Plant — Set Your Foundation

Before you explore anything new, get clear on what you already have and what you actually want.

Calibrate your compass. What are your real values — not what should matter, but what actually does? What energizes you versus drains you? What are your non-negotiables?

> *Recruiter reality check: I see candidates who haven't figured this out take jobs for money, then quit six months later because the culture is toxic. They chase titles without considering whether the role uses their strengths. Know your compass before you start searching.*

Set a 1-year vision. Not 5 years, not 10. Where do you want to be in one year? Be specific. "I want to be leading a team of 5 engineers working on AI infrastructure" is useful. "I want a better job" is not.

Identify your strengths. What are you naturally good at? What do people come to you for? What skills transfer to new contexts? Successful pivots leverage existing strengths in new

ways, engineers pivot to product management, consultants pivot to internal strategy, teachers pivot to corporate training. They don't start from zero. They re-aim.

Fund your runway. You cannot pivot from financial desperation. Save 3-6 months of expenses minimum before making any major move. Desperation kills your negotiating power. When I'm hiring, I can sense when a candidate *needs* the job versus *wants* the job. The ones who want it get better offers.

✅ **Action steps for Stage 1:**

1. Write down your top 3-4 values (the real ones, not the aspirational ones)
2. Complete this sentence: "In one year, I want to be ___" with as much specificity as possible
3. List 5 things you're genuinely good at that people rely on you for
4. Calculate your runway: monthly expenses × 6 = your savings target

---

🔍 Stage 2: Scan — Gather Intelligence

Now that you know your foundation, research where you want to go and what it takes to get there.

Build your network before you need it. 70-80% of jobs are filled through networks, not job postings. When I open a role at Uber, my first step is asking my team "who do we know?" If someone vouches for a candidate, they jump to the front of the line. Cold applicants need to be exceptional to get noticed.

Don't think of networking as asking for favors. Think of it as building two-way relationships. Give first, ask later.

Bridge your skill gaps, but be smart about it. You don't need every item on the job description. From my experience screening resumes, a 60-70% match is often enough if you can tell a good story about the gaps. Focus on the skills that are most critical for the role, hardest to learn on the job, and most valued in your target market.

Make yourself discoverable. Don't define yourself by your current job title. Define yourself by the problems you solve. "I'm working on user acquisition strategies for SaaS products" beats "I'm a marketing manager looking to pivot."

> *Recruiter reality check: The "spray and resume" approach — applying to 100 jobs — rarely works for career pivoters. Targeted visibility works better. Be known by 10 people in your target field who can vouch for you. That's more powerful than 100 cold applications.*

✅ **Action steps for Stage 2:**

1. Find 5 people already working in your target field, ask for 20-minute coffee chats

2. List the top 3 skills your target role requires that you don't have yet
3. Pick ONE skill gap to start closing this month (online course, side project, or training)
4. Update your LinkedIn profile to describe problems you solve, not just titles you've held
5. Tell 3 trusted people in your network what you're exploring, let them help connect dots

---

🧪 Stage 3: Pilot — Test Before You Commit

This is the most important stage, and the one most people skip entirely. Instead of making one big leap, run small experiments to gather real-world data.

People quit their jobs to "pursue their dreams," then discover they hate the reality of that dream. Pilots prevent this expensive mistake.

A strong pilot is: low risk (can be done while employed), low cost (minimal financial investment), reversible (if it doesn't work), and provides real data (not just theory).

Examples of pilots:

- Freelance project in your target industry — tests: can you do the work? Do you enjoy it?
- Side project on weekends — tests: genuine interest, skill level, market demand
- Consulting for 1-2 clients while employed — tests: business viability
- Teaching a workshop — tests: expertise, interest in education
- Volunteering in the new field — tests: culture, day-to-day reality

Aim for quantity. Run 5-10 small experiments, not 1 perfect test. If you're testing freelance writing, don't pitch one article and quit. Pitch 20, complete 5, join 2 communities, interview 3 full-time writers. Aggregate the data before deciding.

After each pilot, ask three questions:

1. What worked? (What energized me? What feedback did I get?)
2. What didn't? (What drained me? What was harder than expected?)
3. What's next? (Continue? Try a variation? Run a different experiment?)

> *Recruiter reality check: When I review resumes from career pivoters, I look for proof of pilots. Someone going from consulting to product management should have product side projects, experience with product teams, or evidence of product thinking. Without pilots, you're asking employers to take a bigger risk on you. With pilots, you have proof.*

The golden rule: if you hate the pilot, you'll hate the pivot. Better to find out now while you still have your job and income.

✅ **Action steps for Stage 3:**

1. Design your first pilot — what's the smallest experiment you can run this week?
2. Set a goal: run at least 3 pilots within the next 2 months
3. After each pilot, write down what you learned in 3 sentences
4. Talk to 3 people already doing your target job — compare their reality to your expectations

---

🚀 Stage 4: Launch — Make the Move

Launch is not about courage. Blake's key insight: **build first, courage second.**

When you've done Plant, Scan, and Pilot properly, the launch becomes less scary because it's data-driven, not fear-driven.

Define your launch criteria. These are specific conditions that must be true before you make your move. Write them down. Be honest with yourself.

Financial criteria:

- ☐ Emergency fund of ___ months saved
- ☐ Side income of $___ established (if applicable)
- ☐ Major debt reduced to manageable level

Professional criteria:

- ☐ ___ paying clients lined up / job offer secured
- ☐ Key certifications or skills acquired
- ☐ Portfolio with ___ strong examples

Personal criteria:

- ☐ Partner/family supportive of the change
- ☐ Living situation stable
- ☐ Mental and physical health in a good place

Don't wait for perfect conditions. There's no perfect time to make a career change. Launch when your criteria are met, even if you're still scared. Fear is normal. Paralysis is optional.

✅ **Action steps for Stage 4:**

1. Write your launch criteria checklist — be specific and measurable
2. For each criterion, identify what's already met vs. what still needs work
3. Set a deadline: "I will make a decision by [date]"
4. Prepare your transition conversations (boss, family) — make the decision first, plan the conversations second

---

🎯 Stage 5: Lead — Help Others Pivot

Once you've pivoted successfully, share what you learned. Help others through their transitions. Make introductions. Review resumes. Celebrate other people's career wins.

Career karma is real. The more you help others pivot successfully, the more support you'll have when you need your next one.

✅ **Action steps for Stage 5:**

1. Share your pivot story with at least one person who's considering a similar move
2. Offer to review a resume or do a mock interview for someone in transition
3. Connect two people in your network who could help each other

---

The 5 Mistakes I See Every Week

1. Quitting before testing. Always pilot first. The reality of a career rarely matches the idea of it. Gather data while you're still employed and have income.

2. Starting from scratch. You don't need a completely new identity. Find the adjacent move — one step from where you are now. Leverage what you already have. Consultant → internal strategy. Engineer → product management. Teacher → corporate training.

3. Analysis paralysis. At some point, more research doesn't help — you need experience. Set a decision deadline. 20 informational interviews teach you less than one freelance project actually doing the work.

4. No financial runway. Desperation kills negotiations. It's obvious in how quickly candidates accept offers, how little they negotiate, how they frame questions. Save 3-6 months expenses before any major launch.

5. Skipping the network. Applying to 100 jobs online without talking to a single person in the target field is the slowest path to a career change. Most jobs are filled through connections. Your resume matters less than who's championing you internally.

Start Here

If you're employed and uncertain → Start with Plant. Clarify your compass and 1-year vision.

If you know where you want to go → Move to Scan. Build your network and bridge skill gaps.

If you've done your research → Run Pilots. Test your assumptions with real experiments.

If you've tested and validated → Check your Launch criteria. Set a decision deadline.

If you've already pivoted → Lead. Help others through their transitions.

The only move that matters is your next one.

📥 **Get the full guide with exercises, detailed examples, and visual frameworks:** [LEAD_MAGNET_URL]

James Bugden • Senior Recruiter @ Uber Taiwan Based on "Pivot: The Only Move That Matters Is Your Next One" by Jenny Blake. All framework concepts and methodology credit goes to Jenny Blake.